

Activity 9 — Implementation Planning and Stakeholder Resistance

ShopFront SG — the rollout that has to survive contact with people

Topic	Topic 3
Objective	A6 · K3, K8 — Draw up implementation plans and address factors affecting effectiveness.
Duration	50 minutes
Grouping	Teams of 3-5
Tools	ChatGPT / Copilot / Gemini, Pinboard
Ed-tool	Pinboard — https://alfredang.github.io/pinboard/

The Scenario

Return to ShopFront SG from Activity 1. The diagnosis is complete and the solution set is approved: a one-page guest checkout, a CDN and caching layer to bring app load under 2 seconds, a supplier QC checklist to cut the return rate, and cart-recovery notifications.

The Chief Operating Officer has seen improvement projects die before. She says:

"The plan is fine. Now tell me who is going to fight it, why, and what you are going to do about it. Last year we bought a S\$400,000 CRM that nobody used. It worked perfectly. That was not the problem."

Your team must build the implementation plan AND the stakeholder strategy that makes it stick. Assume nothing about goodwill.

The Evidence

ShopFront SG — stakeholder map and known positions

Stakeholder	Interest	Likely position
IT Development team	Already at capacity on a POS migration	Resist — sees added workload
Head of Marketing	Sponsored the S\$180k discount campaign	Resist — solution implies her spend was wrong
Store Operations	In-store sales flat, feels unaffected	Indifferent — 'not my problem'
Suppliers (12 vendors)	Face new QC standards and possible delisting	Resist — cost and scrutiny
Customer Service	Handling 410 tickets/week, overloaded	Support — expects relief
Finance	Approved budget, wants ROI evidence	Conditional — needs measurement
COO (sponsor)	Accountable for the turnaround	Champion
Frontline retail staff	Fear digital shift reduces store headcount	Anxious — job security

Discussion Questions

1. Build the implementation plan for all four solutions. Which two MUST be sequenced rather than run in parallel, and what breaks if you ignore that?
2. The Head of Marketing resists because the diagnosis implies her S\$180k campaign was misdirected. This is a face problem, not a logic problem. How do you secure her cooperation without requiring her to admit error?
3. Frontline retail staff fear the digital push costs them jobs. Is that fear irrational? What would you actually commit to — and what happens to your credibility if you promise something you cannot guarantee?
4. Twelve suppliers face new QC standards. What is the difference between imposing the checklist and getting them to adopt it, and which one survives after month three?
5. Identify the single stakeholder most likely to sink this rollout. Note: it may not be the loudest one. Justify your choice.

Step-by-Step

6. Review the four approved ShopFront SG solutions and the stakeholder map.
7. Build the implementation plan: for each solution write Action, Method/Tool, Owner, Timeline.
8. Draw the four solutions on a timeline and mark dependencies with arrows. Identify what must not run in parallel.
9. For each of the eight stakeholders, write their objection IN THEIR OWN WORDS — first person, as they would actually say it in a meeting.
10. For each, decide what they need to hear or receive to move from their current position.
11. Assign a MESSENGER to each stakeholder and justify why that person rather than you.
12. Run the GenAI change management prompt from the slide.
13. Compare the AI's stakeholder analysis to yours. Note any objection it named more bluntly than your team was willing to write down — and ask why you softened it.
14. Rank all stakeholders by their power to block the rollout. Debate the top one as a team.
15. Build the 90-day communication plan: what, to whom, how often, by whom.
16. Post your stakeholder strategy to <https://alfredang.github.io/pinboard/> and present your most dangerous stakeholder plus your mitigation.

The GenAI Prompt

Act as a change management and implementation planning advisor for a Singapore fashion retailer.

Approved solutions: (1) one-page guest checkout; (2) CDN + caching to bring app load from 4.8s to under 2.0s; (3) supplier QC checklist to cut the 12% return rate; (4) automated cart-recovery notifications.

PART A – Implementation plan. For each solution give ONLY:

- Action (what will be done)
- Method/tool (how)

- Owner and timeline (who, by when)
- Sequencing note (what must happen before it)

PART B – Stakeholder strategy. Stakeholders and positions:

IT Development (at capacity, resists workload); Head of Marketing (sponsored a S\$180k campaign the diagnosis implies was misdirected – resists); Store Operations (indifferent); 12 suppliers (face new QC standards – resist); Customer Service (supportive, overloaded); Finance (conditional on ROI evidence); COO (champion); frontline retail staff (fear job loss).

For EACH stakeholder give:

- Their specific objection in THEIR words, not yours
- What they need to hear or receive to move
- One concrete action to secure their cooperation
- Who is best placed to deliver that message and why

PART C – Name the single stakeholder most likely to sink this rollout, and explain what makes them dangerous. Then give a 90-day communication plan: what is communicated, to whom, how often, by whom.

Be blunt about political realities. Do not assume goodwill.

Trainer Debrief

Expected answers and the points to draw out. Trainer reference.

EXPECTED IMPLEMENTATION SEQUENCING:

Guest checkout (weeks 1-4, quick win — builds momentum and credibility with Finance).

CDN/caching (weeks 2-10, big bet — MUST precede or accompany cart-recovery notifications; driving traffic back to a 4.8-second app converts a recovery campaign into a second bad experience and burns the customer twice).

Supplier QC (weeks 3-16, longest lead time — external parties, contractual change).

Cart recovery (weeks 10-14, AFTER load time is fixed).

STAKEHOLDER STRATEGY — the key moves:

MARKETING is the classic trap. The objection is not logical, it is reputational. The move is to reframe rather than relitigate: the campaign proved demand exists; conversion is where it leaks. Give her ownership of the cart-recovery workstream so she wins visibly from the fix. Delivered by the COO, peer to peer — never by the analyst who produced the diagnosis.

IT DEVELOPMENT resists capacity, not the idea. The move is real relief, not encouragement: re-sequence the POS migration, or fund contract capacity. Delivered by the COO because only the sponsor can re-prioritise.

SUPPLIERS respond to incentives, not instructions. Co-design the checklist with the three best-performing vendors, then tie compliance to order volume. An imposed checklist is complied with on paper for two months; a co-designed one with commercial consequence sticks.

FRONTLINE STAFF have a rational fear and deserve an honest answer. Commit to what you can actually control — no headcount reduction tied to this programme, and involvement in click-and-collect roles. Never promise what you cannot guarantee; one broken promise here costs you every subsequent change programme.

STORE OPERATIONS indifference is the quiet risk — click-and-collect needs them and they have no reason to care yet. Give them a stake before you need them.

MOST DANGEROUS STAKEHOLDER — accept a well-argued case for either, but push teams past the obvious: IT Development can hard-block delivery (nothing ships without them), while Marketing can soft-block through political attrition, which is harder to see and harder to escalate. Many teams name the loudest resister; the more sophisticated answer notes that INDIFFERENCE (Store Operations) often kills rollouts more quietly than opposition, because nobody escalates an absence of enthusiasm.

KEY TEACHING POINTS:

1. THE COO'S LINE IS THE WHOLE LESSON: the CRM 'worked perfectly. That was not the problem.' Solutions fail on ADOPTION far more often than on design. K8 — factors affecting the effectiveness of an implementation plan — is mostly about people, not technology.
2. MESSENGER MATTERS AS MUCH AS MESSAGE. The same words land differently from the COO, a peer, or the analyst. Teams consistently under-think this; make them assign a messenger to every message and justify it.
3. RESISTANCE IS INFORMATION. IT's objection reveals a genuine capacity conflict your plan had not costed. Suppliers' objection reveals the checklist needs commercial teeth. Treating resistance as data improves the plan; treating it as obstruction guarantees failure.

4. GenAI is unusually good here because it has no stake in the office politics — it will state plainly that Marketing's objection is about face, which a junior analyst may not dare write down. It is weak on the specific human relationships and history, which only the team knows. Divide the labour accordingly.

Self-Check — Is Your Output Finished?

Your implementation plan is realistic when: every solution has an action, method, owner and timeline; dependencies are sequenced (cart recovery AFTER load time is fixed); every stakeholder has an objection written in their own voice, a specific move, and a named messenger; you have identified the highest-risk blocker with justification; and your communication plan runs the full 90 days rather than stopping at launch. If your plan assumes everyone cooperates because the analysis is correct, you have written a wish, not a plan.